

Checklist:

Product Vision and Principles Checklist

1. Establish the strategic context

- ☐ Confirm that the company's mission, objectives, and scorecard are clear
- ☐ Ensure the product vision supports company objectives
- ☐ Define how the vision connects to product strategy
- ☐ Align team topology to the vision

2. Create a compelling product vision

- ☐ Make the vision customer-centric
- ☐ Describe the future you want to create for customers
- ☐ Focus on the end state, not the implementation plan
- ☐ Make it ambitious and meaningful
- ☐ Ensure it provides a shared “North Star” for all teams
- ☐ Make the bigger picture understandable to every team
- ☐ Clarify how each team contributes to the larger whole
- ☐ Set a long-term horizon, typically 3–10 years
- ☐ Leverage relevant industry trends, not fads
- ☐ Keep the emphasis on customer value, not technology for its own sake

3. Make the vision actionable across the organization

- ☐ Use the vision to guide product strategy
- ☐ Use the vision to shape architecture decisions
- ☐ Use the vision to inform team structure and topology
- ☐ Give engineering enough clarity about what is coming
- ☐ Avoid confusing the vision with a feature roadmap
- ☐ Avoid giving each product team its own separate vision

4. Build the right ownership

- ☐ Ensure the head of product owns the development of the vision
- ☐ Involve the design closely in shaping the vision
- ☐ Involve technology leadership closely in shaping the vision
- ☐ Ensure the CEO/GM feels genuine ownership of the vision
- ☐ Prepare leaders to repeatedly communicate and “sell” the vision internally and externally

5. Communicate the vision effectively

- ☐ Tell the story from the user’s perspective
- ☐ Make the vision inspiring, not just informative
- ☐ Create a vision type or conceptual prototype
- ☐ Consider a scripted video to communicate the vision
- ☐ Use storyboarding where helpful
- ☐ Show how different user types experience the future product
- ☐ Involve product designers heavily in crafting the experience and communication

6. Validate the vision appropriately

- ☐ Test whether the underlying customer problems are real
- ☐ Test whether customers care enough about those problems
- ☐ Test whether customers are open to new solutions
- ☐ Accept that you can validate demand, but not fully validate the final solution upfront
- ☐ Treat pursuing the vision as a reasoned leap of faith

7. Use the vision as a leadership tool

- ☐ Use the vision to recruit strong product talent
- ☐ Use the vision to create meaning and purpose for teams
- ☐ Use the vision as an evangelism tool across the company
- ☐ Re-communicate the vision regularly; do not assume one telling is enough
- ☐ Engage executives, investors, sales, marketing, customer success, and other stakeholders

8. Handle roadmap conversations carefully

- ☐ Prefer sharing the product vision over sharing detailed roadmaps
- ☐ Stay stubborn on vision but flexible on details
- ☐ Avoid locking into roadmap promises too early

- ☐ Be careful with forward-looking commitments to customers
- ☐ Share only high-integrity commitments when necessary

9. Define product principles

- ☐ Write a clear set of product principles that complement the vision
- ☐ Use principles to guide day-to-day decisions
- ☐ Make principles explicit enough to help with trade-offs
- ☐ Explain the reasoning behind each principle
- ☐ Ensure teams understand which values take priority in conflicts

10. Address ethics and trade-offs

- ☐ Identify the major trade-offs teams are likely to face
- ☐ Clarify how to balance goals such as ease of use vs. security
- ☐ Discuss ethics explicitly, not implicitly
- ☐ Consider how the product could be misused
- ☐ Define principles for preventing harmful or unethical outcomes
- ☐ Give teams enough context to make good ethical decisions

11. Final quality check

- ☐ The vision is compelling
- ☐ The vision is customer-centered
- ☐ The vision is shared across teams
- ☐ The vision informs strategy, architecture, and team design
- ☐ The principles support real trade-off decisions
- ☐ The organization can explain the vision simply and consistently

